Physical Appearance and Elections: An Inequality Perspective

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- **Motivate the problem**: It's clear that **physically attractive candidates win elections more often**.
- **Gaps in the literature**: The literature *only* looks at candidate attractiveness, which is just *one* dimension of physical appearance.
- Our paper:
  - **Beyond attractiveness**: explore the degree in which **a candidate's occupation is congruent with his/her physical appearance**.
  - **Inequality perspective**: Study how the candidate's **social class** affects voting.
- **Empirics**: we exploit a novel data set of candidate's physical appearance in the context of the 2017 Finnish Municipal Elections.
- **Results**: Find that Finns vote systematically more for "upper-class" candidates, but that there are important gender differences.

Good-looking Candidates do Better in Elections

- Better-looking candidates are more likely to win elections.
- Dion et al. (1972) we know that "beautiful is good" and that "voters vote beautiful" (Efrain and Patterson, 1974).



"What Are Good-Looking Candidates?" (Stockemer and Praino, 2019)

Nixon-Kennedy 1960 Debate

- Nixon's "five-o'clock" shadow largely affected voter evaluations.

  Mattes et. al (2010).

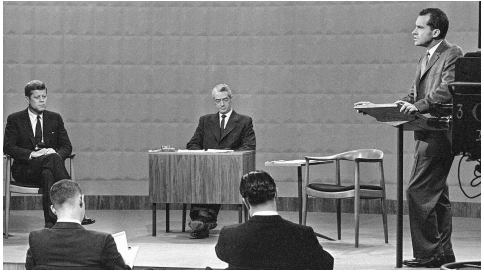


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- Radio listeners thought Nixon would win, while TV-watchers though Kennedy would.



Gaps in the Current Literature

- While the literature has advanced a number of important questions, its focus has been on just **attractiveness**.
- We believe that physical *appearance* goes way beyond *attractiveness*.
- Even while some have studied how "looking *competent*" (and not necessarily "*beautiful*") helps candidates winning elections, there are a number of unanswered questions.
- Importantly, several of these questions are related to inequality.
- **In this paper we want to explain voting**: *Does it matter if the candidate look like a working-class individual as opposed to a white-collar individual?*

To Fill These Gaps...

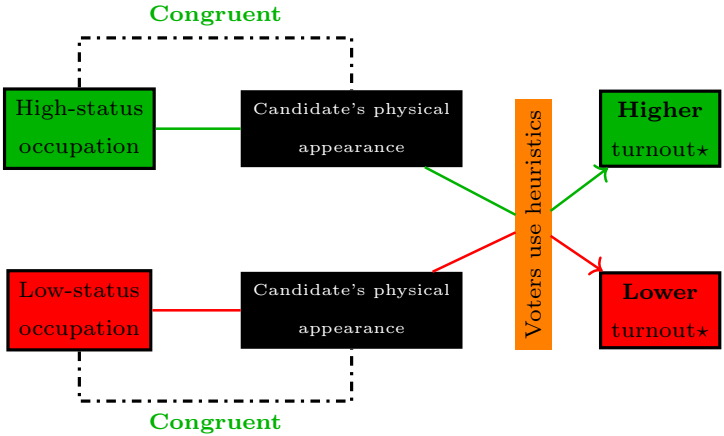
- Study the electoral consequences for candidates of **looking** "upper-class," "middle-class" or "working-class."
- Exploit a **novel data** set were we are able to measure different physical appearance aspects of a subsample of political candidates.
- **Find** that Finns vote systematically more for "upper-class" candidates, but that there are important gender differences.

Political Psychology

- A candidate's **physical appearance** is "the most important" (Lau & Redlawsk 2001) and the "most obvious and accessible" (Dion et al. 1972) *heuristic* available to voters (Stockemer & Praino 2017).
- **Heuristics** are cognitive devices that allow reasonable voting decision making with minimal effort (Lau & Redlawsk 2001 and Tversky & Kahneman 1973).
- Thus, "voters vote beautiful" (Efrain & Patterson 1974) because attractive candidates "are more likely to be attributed the qualities associated with successful politicians" (Stockemer & Praino 2019).

Expectation States Theory

- **Expectation States Theory**: physical appearance, gender and occupation "cue social categories and signify social status" making them all a "locus of inequality."
  - "sexual attractiveness" is a gender-specific status symbol: physical attractiveness intersects with gender producing unfavorable outcomes for women.



⋆Particularly for women

Finland as a Hard Case

- We follow a "**least-likely case design**" (Levy 2008). Finland has been consistently considered as:
  - A democratic (Polity-V).
  - An economic egalitarian (Waltl 2022).
  - A gender egalitarian.
  - A social-mobility prone country (Erola 2009).
- Thus, it should be **hard to find** a correlation between class-congruent use of status symbols and voting.

...and yet, we *do*.

Municipal Elections in Finland

- **Municipal Elections**: held every four years to elect councilors of the different municipalities (N=293).
- **D'Hondt**: candidates run in party lists. Sits are filled with lists of candidates proportionally.
- **Municipalities**: provide daycare, health, education, water, waste management, among others.

Campaigns: Plain, Simple and Fair

- **"Low-information" elections**: most voters get exposed to only the official candidate pictures shown in the posters.

  (Berggren et al. 2010 & 2017).

- **Public information**: shown in city centers, bus stops, *and* voting booths!
- Municipalities *must* provide the *same* number of poster slots for all parties.



Average Poster Displaying Candidates Faces in Finnish Elections

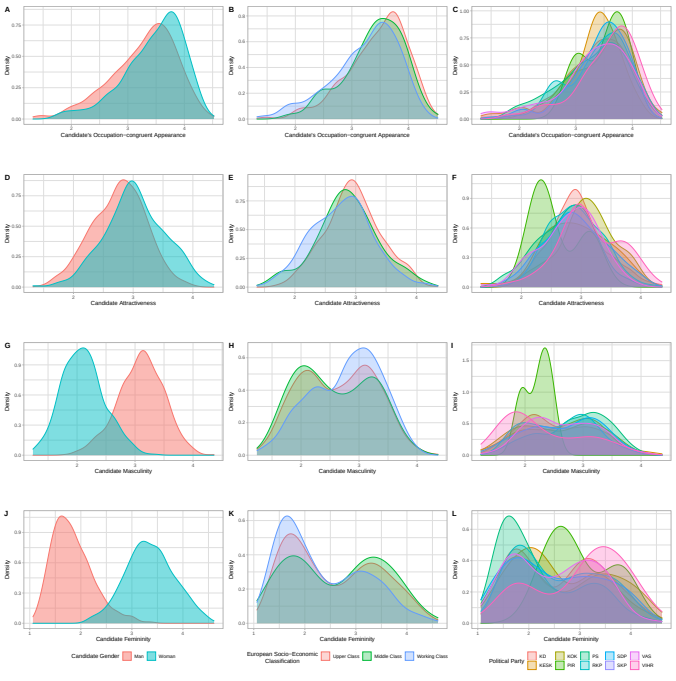
2017 Municipal Elections: Candidate Data

- **Ministry of Justice**: candidate's pictures, district, occupation and voting data.
- **Sample**: Universe 33,618, possible 10,000, randomly selected **1,500 candidate photographs**.
- **Occupation**: European Socio-economic Classification, recoded each candidate's occupation (upper, middle and working class).

Novel Raters Data

- **Sample**: able to collect data from 7,920 randomly selected Finnish-speaking Finns.
- **Task**: participants evaluated a random sample of candidate photographs according to five items (N∼50).
- **Items**:
  1. **Occupation-Congruent Appearance.**
  2. **Attractiveness.**
  3. **Masculinity.**
  4. **Femininity.**
- **Avoiding recognition**: proprietary software designed to avoid assigning candidates running in the same district of the rater's.

▸ show table with items


A
B
C
D
E
F
G
H
I
J
K
L
Density
Candidate's Occupation−congruent Appearance
Candidate Attractiveness
Candidate Masculinity
Candidate Femininity
Candidate Gender
Man
Woman
European Socio−Economic Classification
Upper Class
Middle Class
Working Class
Political Party
KD
KESK
KOK
PIR
PS
REP
SDP
SKP
VAS
VIHR

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i \sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\text{Votes}_i = \beta_0 + \\
&\beta_1 \text{Occupation-congruent Appearance} \times \text{Social Class} + \\
&\beta_2 \text{Age} + \\
&\gamma 1 \text{Party} + \\
&\gamma 2 \text{City}
\end{aligned}
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- **Also control for**: Attractiveness, Masculinity and Femininity.
- **Partition the data** (full, men & women).

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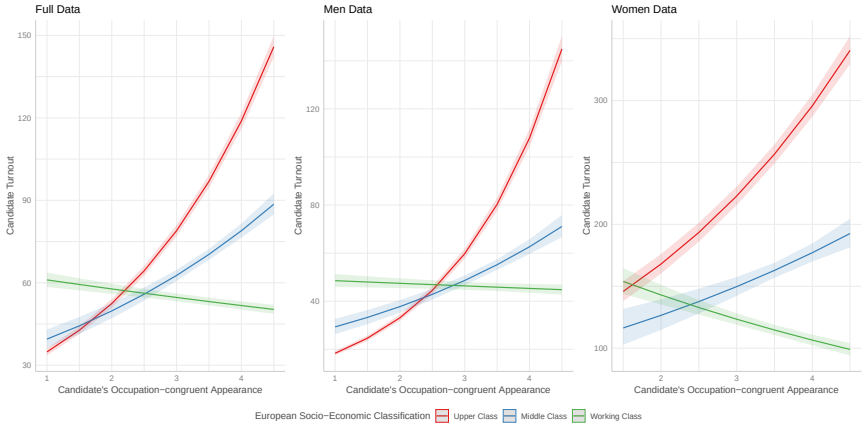
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Table: Statistical Models

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
	Full	Men	Women	Full	Full	Full	Men	Women	Men	Women	Men	Women
Intercept	4.49***	2.58***	6.17***	2.11***	4.27***	2.15***	−0.25**	3.24***	2.50***	2.98***	0.17	2.80***
	(0.05)	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.08)
Physical Occupation-Congruent	0.41***	0.59***	0.28***	0.25***	0.42***	0.26***	0.37***	0.22***	0.59***	0.28***	0.37***	0.24***
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Middle Class	0.30***	0.81***	−0.05	0.41***	0.23***	0.31***	0.54***	0.12	0.77***	0.18	0.75***	0.16
	(0.06)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.08)	(0.11)
Working Class	1.03***	1.59***	0.70***	0.49***	1.07***	0.58***	0.95***	0.23***	1.59***	0.32***	0.86***	0.19**
	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.04)	(0.07)
Age	−0.02***	−0.01***	−0.03***	−0.00***	−0.02***	−0.01***	0.00***	−0.01***	−0.01***	−0.02***	0.01***	−0.01***
	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)
Physical Occupation-Congruent × Middle Class	−0.18***	−0.34***	−0.11***	−0.20***	−0.16***	−0.17***	−0.22***	−0.17***	−0.33***	−0.19***	−0.28***	−0.18***
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.03)
Physical Occupation-Congruent × Working Class	−0.46***	−0.61***	−0.43***	−0.28***	−0.48***	−0.31***	−0.39***	−0.28***	−0.62***	−0.29***	−0.35***	−0.27***
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.02)
Attractiveness				0.76***		0.89***	1.00***	0.72***			1.08***	0.53***
				(0.01)		(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)			(0.01)	(0.01)
Masculinity					0.09***				0.04***		−0.28***	
					(0.00)				(0.01)		(0.01)	
Femininity						−0.15***				0.68***		0.26***
						(0.00)				(0.01)		(0.02)
AIC	287653.94	170596.79	79111.45	267973.43	287029.77	265328.79	154959.12	73290.19	170577.24	74331.79	153861.01	73001.39
BIC	288886.12	171561.82	79936.45	269210.66	288267.17	266571.24	155928.83	74119.20	171546.96	75161.13	154835.41	73834.74
Log Likelihood	−143590.97	−85092.40	−39365.73	−133749.72	−143277.88	−132426.40	−77272.56	−36454.09	−85081.62	−36974.89	−76722.51	−36308.70
Deviance	278666.41	165250.11	75150.60	258990.24	278040.23	256343.60	149610.43	69333.68	165228.56	70368.94	148510.33	69042.88
Num. obs.	1368	800	568	1367	1368	1367	800	567	800	568	800	567

$^{***}p < 0.001$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{*}p < 0.05$.
Dependent variable is Turnout. City fixed effects and party variables omitted. The reference category in the ESEC variable is 'Upper Class.' Given the symmetry of the derivatives, changing the reference category does not alter the interpretation of the results. Functional form is Poisson regression for all models.

Main Results



Main Results

- **Male & female** candidates:
  - ✓ Candidates that show *higher degrees of congruence* between physical appearance and occupation do better.
  - ✓ Candidates that look-like and also perform *upper-class occupations* do best in elections.
- **Female** candidates: stronger effects.
  - Systematic electoral penalty when they **look-like** and also **perform working-class occupations**.
  - Systematic electoral premium when they **look-like** and also **perform white-collar occupations**.

Main Takeaways

- ✓ Considered **the use of heuristics in elections** and the concept of **"status" in expectation states theory**.
- ✓ Selected the ***unlikely* case** of the 2017 Finnish Municipal Elections.
- ✓ Exploited a **novel representative data set** on candidates physical appearances.
- ✓ Proposed an alternative explanation for voting not based on attractiveness but on occupation-congruent appearance and social stratification.

Thank you

All feedback is welcomed!

Raters Data: Questions and Answer Set

Sample	Attribute	Question	Answer Set
1	Occupation-Congruent Appearance	To what extent does this person respond to your image of someone working in [occupation]?	5=Perfectly responds to my image, 4=Responds well to my image, 3=Somewhat responds to my image, 2=Does not respond to my image well, 1=Does not respond to my image at all.
2	Attractiveness	In your opinion, how attractive does this person look, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	5=very attractive, 4=more attractive than the average, 3=average, 2=below average, 1=well below average (Griffin and Langois 2006; Bono et al. 2017; Tu, Gilbert and Bono 2021)
3	Masculinity	To what extent do you think this person looks masculine, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	1=not masculine at all, to 5=very masculine (e.g., Hoss et al. 2005).
4	Femininity	To what extent do you think this person looks feminine, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	1=not feminine at all, to 5=very feminine.